



BUCKET LIST

Australian Birds

“From rainforest to reef, collect them all.”

2-5
PLAYERS

8+
AGES

20-30
MINUTES

1.5
WEIGHT

A card-drafting and grid-building game for two to five birdwatchers.

Draft birds from the market, lay them out in your own grid, and line up matching habitats and diets to score. Every bird is real and every fact printed on the card is true.

Then there is the tick box. Whenever you see one of these birds for real - deep in a rainforest, out on a headland, or on the power line outside the kitchen window - tick it off. The ticks are permanent. Your copy slowly becomes the record of a lifetime of birdwatching, and it starts scoring you points for it.

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Part of the Bucket List series - one ruleset, many subjects.

The Idea

Bucket List: Australian Birds is a game about noticing things. One hundred cards, one hundred real species, from the cassowary that can knock a man over to the magpie that has learned your face.

On your turn you take a bird from the market and add it to your grid. That is the whole turn. The interesting part is where it goes: every card you place is a promise about the shape you are building, and the grid is only ever thirty cells wide with twenty birds to fit into it.

OBJECT OF THE GAME

Arrange your birds so that four or more in a row or column share a symbol. Every such run is worth a point. The player with the most points at the end of the game wins.

COMPONENTS

- 100 unique bird cards
- This rule book

Card type	Count	Symbols carried
Standard	90	1 habitat + 1 diet
Wild habitat	5	WILD habitat + 1 diet
Wild diet	5	1 habitat + WILD diet
Total	100	No card is wild in both

The ninety standard cards cover all twenty-five combinations of habitat and diet, so no pairing is ever impossible to find - only hard to wait for.

Every fact on every card is true. If a bird on a card claims it can mimic a chainsaw, it can.

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Anatomy of a Card



- 1 **The bird.** Its common name, and a photograph of the species.
- 2 **Habitat symbol.** Always an oval, always on the left. Where this bird is found.
- 3 **Diet symbol.** Always a rectangle, always on the right. What this bird eats.
- 4 **Field note.** One true thing about the bird.
- 5 **Tick box.** Empty on a new card. Tick it when you have seen this bird in real life - see **Field Notes** on page 8.

Two symbols, never more
Every card carries exactly one habitat symbol and exactly one diet symbol. Learn to read a card at a glance by its two corners: oval on the left, rectangle on the right.

A new copy and an old one
Out of the box every tick box is empty and the game is a clean symbol-matching puzzle. Years later, with half the boxes ticked, the same hundred cards play quite differently. See **Field Notes** on page 8.



Twenty of the hundred. Every one of them is somewhere in this deck, and every one of them is somewhere out there.

Ten symbols are the entire vocabulary of the game. Five habitats say where a bird lives; five diets say what it eats. Matching them is the only thing you ever score for.

Habitats

Oval symbols, on the left of every card.



Rainforest

The wet forests of the east coast and the tropical north.



Bushland & Scrub

Dry eucalypt woodland, mallee, heath and the suburban back fence.



Wetlands & Waterways

Swamps, billabongs, rivers, reed beds and lagoons.



Coastal & Ocean

Beaches, headlands, estuaries, islands and the open sea.



Outback & Grassland

The arid interior, the spinifex and the open plains.

Diets

Rectangular symbols, on the right of every card.



Seeds & Grain

Parrots, finches, pigeons and cockatoos.



Nectar & Fruit

Honeyeaters, lorikeets, fruit-doves and bowerbirds.



Insects & Invertebrates

Fairywrens, robins, bee-eaters and anything that probes mud.



Fish & Aquatic Prey

Kingfishers, herons, gannets, pelicans and the odd frog.



Meat & Carrion

Eagles, owls, falcons, butcherbirds and cheerful scavengers.

The Ten Wild Birds

Ten famous species are so widespread, or so catholic in their tastes, that they refuse to sit in one box. Each of them is **wild in exactly one of its two symbols**, marked with a gold star.

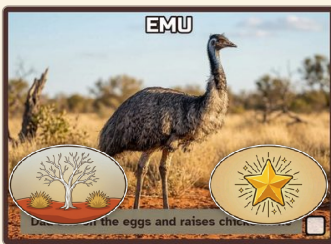
A wild habitat counts as whichever habitat you need it to be. A wild diet counts as whichever diet you need it to be. You decide when you score, not when you place, and the same wild card may be read one way across its row and another way down its column.

No card is wild twice

Every wild bird still carries one ordinary symbol. The Emu is wild in diet but firmly an outback bird; the Galah is wild in habitat but always eating seeds.

Wild habitat	Fixed diet
Galah	Seeds & Grain
Figbird	Nectar & Fruit
Satin Bowerbird	Insects & Invertebrates
Darter	Fish & Aquatic Prey
Peregrine Falcon	Meat & Carrion

Wild diet	Fixed habitat
Southern Cassowary	Rainforest
Superb Lyrebird	Bushland & Scrub
Purple Swamphen	Wetlands & Waterways
Little Penguin	Coastal & Ocean
Emu	Outback & Grassland



Four of the ten wilds. The Galah and Figbird carry a star where their habitat would be; the Emu and Little Penguin carry one where their diet would be. Symbols are shown enlarged in all diagrams in this book.

Setup

- 1 **Shuffle.** Shuffle all 100 bird cards together.
- 2 **Build the play deck.** Count out **20 cards per player** without looking at them. Return the remainder to the box, unseen and out of the game.
- 3 **Deal the market.** Turn the top five cards of the play deck face up in a row in the middle of the table.
- 4 **Make room.** Each player needs clear table space for a grid **six cards wide and five cards high**. Nothing marks the grid out - agree on where your thirty cells are before you start.
- 5 **Choose a start player.** Whoever most recently saw a bird they could not name goes first. Play then proceeds clockwise.

Players	2	3	4	5
Cards in the play deck	40	60	80	100
Cards each player places	20	20	20	20

Everything is open
There is no hand and nothing is hidden. Every card in the market is face up, and every grid on the table can be studied by anyone. The only unknown in the game is what the deck will turn up next.

Ten cells you will never fill
Twenty cards into thirty cells means ten cells stay empty, and you choose which. Empty cells are not wasted space - they are the shape of your grid, and deciding where to leave them is most of the game.

HOW MUCH TABLE YOU NEED
A finished grid is six cards wide, so leave each player roughly the space of a place mat and a half. Play across a long table rather than a round one if you can, and keep the market where everyone can reach it - cards are taken from it constantly.

BEFORE YOUR VERY FIRST GAME
If this copy belongs to you, take five minutes before the first game to go through the deck and tick the birds you have already seen. That is your starting list. If the copy belongs to somebody else, respect their ticks: they are somebody's record, not a house rule.

At five players the whole deck is used and every one of the hundred birds comes out. At two, sixty of them stay in the box, and you will never know which.



The Table, Ready to Play

The market - always five cards, always face up

The deck
20 x players

One player's grid - 6 wide, 5 high, 30 cells

The deck, the market and one player's empty grid. Every other player has a grid of their own, and the market in the middle is shared by everybody.

Three Steps, In Order

Beginning with the start player and going clockwise, each player takes a turn. A turn is always the same three steps.

1 · Draft



Take **one card** from the market. Any of the five, for any reason.

2 · Place



Add it to your grid, **orthogonally adjacent** to a card already there. The Kookaburra slots in below the Noisy Miner.

3 · Refill



Turn cards up from the deck until the market is back to **five**. Your turn ends.

PLACING A CARD

Your **first** card may go in any of the thirty cells of your grid. **Every card after that** must be placed in an empty cell that shares an edge with a card already in your grid - up, down, left or right. Diagonals do not count.

Your grid therefore grows as one connected shape. Cards are never moved, rotated or removed once placed, and you may never place outside the six-by-five area.

You must place what you draft

There is no passing and no discarding. If you take a card, it goes into your grid this turn. There will always be a legal cell for it.

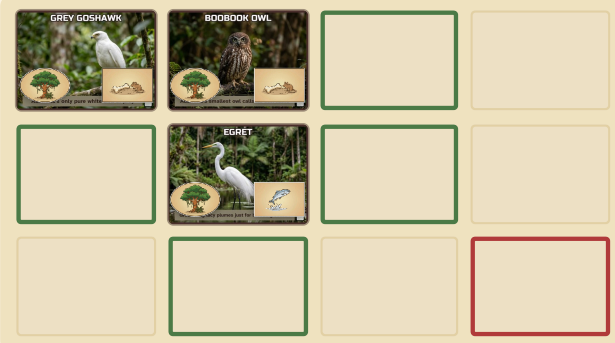
Market refresh (optional)

Before you draft, look at the five market cards. If **three or more of them share a symbol** - the same habitat, or the same diet - you may clear the whole market: slide all five cards into the bottom of the deck, then deal five fresh cards. You then draft from the new market.

You may do this only once per turn, and only when the condition is met. Often you will not want to: three of a kind in the market is sometimes exactly what your grid has been waiting for.



LEGAL AND ILLEGAL PLACEMENTS



Green cells share an edge with a placed bird and are legal. The **red** cell touches nothing at all, so it is not - and a cell touching only a corner would be illegal too.

END OF THE GAME

The game ends when the deck is empty and the last market card has been taken. Because the deck holds exactly twenty cards per player, every player finishes with **exactly twenty birds** in their grid and ten empty cells. Nobody gets an extra turn and nobody misses one.

Then everybody scores.

A FEW THINGS WORTH KNOWING

- You may look at anybody's grid at any time, and count the deck whenever you like.
- Nothing stops two players building towards the same symbol. The market is first come, first served.
- The market never runs dry mid-game: it is refilled at the end of every turn, and only thins out as the deck empties.
- Announce a market refresh before you touch a card. Once you have drafted, the chance has gone until your next turn.

Runs of Four

Read every row and every column of your finished grid. **Each run of four adjacent cards sharing a symbol scores 1 point.**

That is the whole of scoring. Everything below is a consequence of it.

- Habitat runs and diet runs are scored **separately**. One line can score both.
- Runs longer than four **overlap**: five in a line is 2 points, six is 3.
- A **wild** symbol counts as whatever the rest of the run needs.
- An **empty cell** ends a run. Nothing carries across a gap.
- A run lying in a row is a different run from one lying in a column, even where the two cross.
- Diagonals never score.

 habitat run  diet run

FOUR IN A ROW IS ONE POINT

Rainforest x4 = 1 point



The first four birds are all rainforest. The fifth is a bushland lorieet, so the run stops at four. **1 point**.

FIVE IN A ROW IS TWO POINTS

Run 1: cells 1-4

Run 2: cells 2-5



Five nectar-and-fruit birds contain **two** runs of four, in positions 1-4 and 2-5. **2 points**. Six in a line would contain three runs and score 3. The habitats here alternate, so they score nothing.

ONE LINE CAN SCORE TWICE



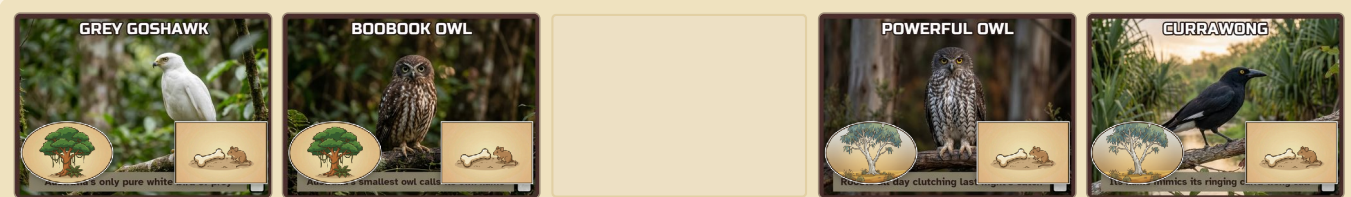
All four are rainforest *and* all four eat nectar and fruit. That is one habitat run plus one diet run: **2 points** from a single line of four cards.

A WILD FILLS THE HOLE



The Galah's habitat is wild, so it reads as rainforest and completes the run. **1 point**. The four diets are all different, so nothing scores there.

AN EMPTY CELL ENDS A RUN



Four meat-and-carrion birds in one row, and not a point between them. The empty cell in the middle splits the line into a two and a two, and runs never jump a gap. **0 points**.

Count a finished grid one line at a time and say each out loud: row 1 to row 5, then column 1 to column 6.

Here is one player's grid at the end of a four-player game: twenty birds placed, ten cells left empty. Let us score it properly, one line at a time.



Columns are numbered 1 to 6 from the left, rows 1 to 5 from the top.

SCORING THE ROWS

Line	What is there	Pts
Row 1	Rainforest in cells 1–4 (the Figbird's wild habitat reads as rainforest)	1
Row 1	Nectar & fruit across all five cells: runs 1–4 and 2–5	2
Row 2	Insects across all five cells: runs 1–4 and 2–5	2
Row 3	Four meat eaters, but the gap at cell 3 splits them	0
Row 4	Four fish eaters, split by the same gap	0
Row 5	Two lonely seed eaters	0
Rows		5

The cost of a gap
Rows 3 and 4 hold eight birds that agree perfectly on diet and score nothing at all. One card in cell 3 of either row would have been worth two points on its own.

SCORING THE COLUMNS

Line	What is there	Pts
Column 1	Rainforest in rows 1–4	1
Column 2	Rainforest in all five rows: runs 1–4 and 2–5	2
Column 3	Two wild birds and three empty cells	0
Column 4	Bushland in rows 2–5	1
Column 5	Bushland in rows 1–4	1
Column 6	Empty	0
Columns		5
Rows		5
Columns		5
Field Notes bonus - columns 1, 2 and 3 are fully ticked in this copy (page 8)		3
Final score		13

Ten points from symbols is a respectable grid. Scores usually land between 10 and 20.

Field Notes

This is the thematic heart of Bucket List, and it is optional only in the sense that a brand new copy has not started using it yet.

THE TICK

Every card has an empty box in the bottom corner. Over the life of your copy of the game, whenever you see one of these birds **in real life**, tick its box. Not on television. Not in a zoo, unless you are generous with yourself. In the wild, with your own eyes.

Ticks are permanent and they accumulate. They belong to the copy of the game, not to a player.

THE BONUS

At the end of the game, after scoring runs, look at each row and each column of your grid. **Score 1 extra point for every line in which every card present is ticked.**

- Empty cells in the line are ignored.
- A line with no cards at all scores nothing.
- A line holding a single ticked card scores the bonus.



Column 1 of the worked example on page 7. Four rainforest birds, all four ticked: 1 point for the run, and 1 more for the Field Notes bonus.

HOW IT GROWS

Your copy	What the game becomes
Nothing ticked	A clean symbol-matching puzzle. Field Notes is dormant.
About half ticked	Tension. You start taking a ticked bird over a better symbol.
Nearly all ticked	A second scoring axis that rewards dense, unbroken grids.

Whose ticks are they?

The ticks belong to the copy. Everyone at the table scores from the same shared list of sightings, which means the owner's birdwatching quietly changes the game for all their friends.

THE BUCKET LIST SERIES

Same rules, new subjects. Australian Birds is one edition; every set in the series swaps in a hundred fresh cards across two trait categories, ten wilds of its own, and its own list of things to go and see.

Quick Reference

SETUP

- Shuffle all 100 cards.
- Play deck = **20 cards × number of players**. Rest to the box, unseen.
- Deal **5** cards face up as the market.
- Each player needs room for a **6 × 5** grid.

YOUR TURN

- **1 Draft.** Take one card from the market.
- **2 Place.** Add it to your grid, orthogonally adjacent to a card already there. First card anywhere.
- **3 Refill.** Top the market back up to five.
- *Optional, before drafting:* if 3+ market cards share a symbol you may bury all five in the bottom of the deck and deal five fresh ones.

GAME END

- Deck empty and market taken. Everyone has exactly **20 cards** and **10 empty cells**.

SCORING

- **+1** per run of four adjacent cards sharing a symbol, in any row or column.
- Habitat runs and diet runs score independently - one line can score both.
- Overlaps count: five in a line = 2, six = 3.
- Wild symbols match anything.
- Empty cells break runs. Diagonals never score.
- **Field Notes:** +1 per row or column in which every card present is ticked.
- Most points wins. On a tie, the tied player with the most ticked cards in their grid wins.



“From rainforest to reef, collect them all.”

Bucket List: Australian Birds · Rule book v1
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